

A tiger spotted at Bandhavgarh National Park, Madhya Pradesh

WATCH OUT FOR
The mariticide-committing giant wood spider, whose majestic cobwebs are often found glistening with morning dew

VISIT
October onwards, when the hot, dry summer and the unpredictable monsoon have passed

ALAMY

Bandhavgarh National Park, Madhya Pradesh

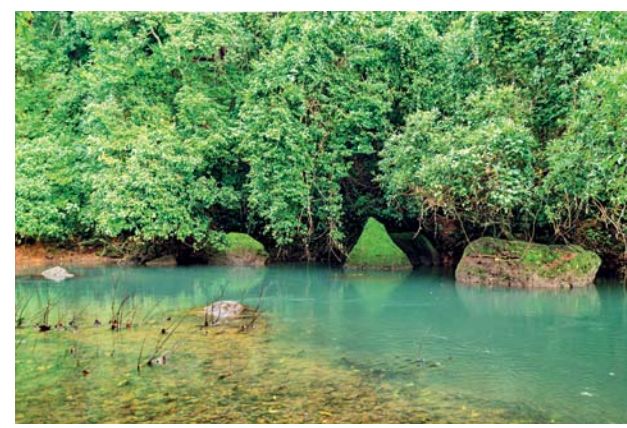
Formerly the hunting grounds of the royals of Rewa, Bandhavgarh is a major part of the reason for Madhya Pradesh's 'Tiger State' status (41 cubs were reported to have been born during the pandemic alone). It recently featured as India's only other national park apart from Jim Corbett National Park on the TripAdvisor Traveler's Choice Award list for national parks. Bandhavgarh's forested hills and sprawling grasslands are home to around 30 species of mammals, including leopards, sloth bears, wild dogs and the gaur, which was reintroduced here in 2011, and over 250 avifauna. History buffs should also visit the Bandhavgarh Fort, which is said to be two millennia old, and the sandstone caves in the northern part of the park that bear Brahmi inscriptions, dating from the 1st century BC.

Mollem National Park, Goa

The tiny coastal state's size undersells its faunal diversity and evergreen flora, both of which are represented in Mollem National Park, a biodiversity hotspot and prime birding zone. Mollem plays host to bird species such as emerald doves, kingfishers, grey junglefowl and the ruby-throated yellow bulbul (the state bird of Goa), besides a great diversity of reptiles. The frothy Dudhsagar Falls is inarguably the most popular tourist attraction, but Mollem, which gained national park status in 1978, has other equally stunning offerings. A case in point is Devil's Canyon, a composite of fascinating rock formations under which the Dudhsagar river finds passage in the monsoons. There are nature hikes to be undertaken, and it's worth trying the five-kilometre trail to the 600-year-old Mahadeva temple.

WATCH OUT FOR
The rich variety of butterflies found in the park, including the blue mormon, Malabar tree nymph and Tamil yeoman

VISIT
in Nov. and Dec., the migratory bird season



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A view of Mollem National Park landscape, Goa

Singalila National Park, West Bengal

In recent years, Singalila—known for its rhododendrons and vintage Land Rovers (Landys) still in service—has attracted increasing scores of serious birders, especially thanks to its vibrant avian denizens, which includes blood pheasants, satyr tragopans, yellow-throated martens, and other, more common old-world groups like babblers and sunbirds. If there is, however, such a thing as a flagship species in any wildlife zone, for Singalila, it's the red panda. Expeditions to sight the endangered elusive raccoon-like bear, will resume this season. The historic Manebhanjan-Sandakphu/Phalut trekking route passes through the park's premises.

WATCH OUT FOR
A view of four of the world's five highest peaks (Mt Everest, Khangchendzonga, Makalu and Lhotse) from Phalut, accessible via a trek from Sandakphu

VISIT
Oct. onwards, during the wildflower blooming season in the lower forests